

entity rather than a shrill modern sport, is a place to check whether their multiplier effect still works. India will hope it does, for that is a well-trodden route to success and redemption.

Each of them have the means. To expert and peer, the core of their qualities lie beneath the surface and beyond glib brand names. Tendulkar's stroke-play comes from a clutter-free creativity, says Javagal Srinath. His gift—carving out an extra instant by first concentrating on reading length alone before making his decision—forward or back. Unlike ordinary batsmen, Tendulkar does not think about where the bowlers arm come from or judging how the ball would swing. Length first, action in the next instant. "That sort of batsman," says former India spinner V.V. Kumar, "is a miracle. It is like he has a sixth sense, one of shot-making."

David's defence is immaculate and his technique sound, but below the accumulated layers of learning and training, at his core, he is a master of the mind. A formidable mind player who brings his preparation to the crease well before the precision tool of his technique comes into play.

After his early flourish, Ganguly's Test cricket has been played before the scrutiny of scowling pundits who say he can't play fast bowling, can't play the pull, doesn't have an onside game, doesn't have patience, doesn't have the bottle. Still, he does have 5,000-plus Test runs and a signature six over long-on that is an offering to the Gods. Tendulkar says, "See, Sourav knows his strengths very well. Singles are not

his style, he likes boundaries. He knows how to set up bowlers." Only three batsmen in history have a better on record and Srinath says, "His game is about domination. Either you overpower Sourav or he overpowers you."

Laxman is the juniormost but his skills seem the most unfathomable. No one can define the meeting point of his technique and his temperament, how he makes his physical art and his mental craft work. "His success," says Kumar, "lies between the extremes of the improbable and the probable." Laxman has often batted as if the scoreboard is irrelevant. He seems more careworn these days but India hopes England will uncork the magic.

Each knows what he would like to borrow from the other. Laxman's wrist-work, says Tendulkar. David's temperament, says Ganguly. Tendulkar's balance, says David. Ganguly's attitude, says Laxman. "When Sourav is at the crease, it's all happening. Whatever shot he has just played on the previous ball, he's still staring the opposition in the eyes."

Batting together, they have built an understanding of each other's tempo and a mutual confidence, unshaken despite a run out or two dozen. Like a long-assembled, much-rehearsed string quartet, their cadences complement rather than compete. David says, "Having them at the other end has helped me play in the rhythm I like." In turn, David has been the solid presence, the steady bass player, around

SHARED HISTORY: Ganguly (left) and David's careers have run parallel



THE TORCH PASSES 1996 - 2000					
BATSMEN	PLAYED	RUNS	AVG	100S	
SACHIN TENDULKAR	38	3553	58.24	14	100 STANDS 24
MOHD. AZHARUDDIN	31	1895	41.19	8	HOME WINS 7
RAHUL DRAVID	37	3505	47.01	6	AWAY WINS 0
SOURAV GANGULY	35	2505	45.54	7	

THE YEARS OF ATTRITION 1982 - 1986					
BATSMEN	PLAYED	RUNS	AVG	100S	
SUNIL GAVASKAR	37	2575	45.17	8	100 STANDS 12
MOHINDER AMARNATH	30	2386	54.22	8	HOME WINS 1
DILIP VENGSAKAR	34	2116	43.18	5	AWAY WINS 2
RAVI SHASTRI	31	1717	38.15	5	